



MONTHLY UPDATE

Malawi: monthly update, July – August 2026

Edition of 2026-08-25 · 57 systems and instruments tracked

Developments summarised from sources published between the beginning of last month and today.

SUMMARY OF THE MONTH · GOVERNANCE · FINANCE · ICT INFRASTRUCTURE · DPI · DIGITALISATION · TECHNOLOGY · CAPACITY · INCLUSION · DATA

Summary of the month

Two things moved in Malawi between 1 July and 6 August 2026, in opposite directions. The data protection regime crossed from paper into scope: the twenty-four-month exemption in the Data Protection Act 2024 elapsed in early June, and on 13 July the regulator consulted on draft regulations, guidelines and a registration fee schedule ([consultation account](#)). At the same time the regulator enforced consumer telecommunications law against both mobile operators, ordering compensation for a tariff-notice breach ([regulator order](#)).

The month also produced the clearest statement yet of what local-government digitisation has not achieved: councils receiving clean audit opinions fell to 18 in 2024/25 from 22, announced on the same day as a public real-time spending dashboard ([launch account](#)).

Governance

Strategies, plans and policies

The draft national artificial intelligence strategy the UNESCO readiness assessment is intended to guide remains pre-adoption.

Legislation and regulation

A consultative meeting concluded in Lilongwe reviewing the National Registration Act and the marriage and family relations statute, with the registration bureau stating the aim is to support a modern and secure civil registration and identification system; no bill, draft or timetable was placed on record.

The statutory copyright society's position on artificial intelligence became public on 23 July: it will not register works created entirely by artificial intelligence or distribute royalties on them. Its own statement is not held, the decision date is not established, and no test was published for how much assistance is admissible.

Data protection

The communications regulator consulted stakeholders at Blantyre on 13 July 2026 on draft Data Protection Regulations and a registration fee schedule setting annual fees by turnover from MWK 50,000 for small and medium enterprises to MWK 7 million for the largest controllers and processors of significant importance ([consultation account](#)). The consultation follows the elapse in early June of the twenty-four-month exemption that had kept most controllers outside the Act's obligations since commencement ([the Act](#)). No commencement date for the regulations was announced.

The regulator's first published position on a specific harm followed on 18 August: a notice warning that [recording, publishing or sharing non-consensual intimate content breaches the Data Protection Act 2024](#), carrying fines to K20,000,000 and up to five years' imprisonment under section 49, with separate penalties under the [Electronic Transactions and Cyber Security Act 2016](#). It states the law rather than applying it: no case, complaint count or enforcement action accompanies it, and enforcement under the Act remains *Not held*.

Regional collaboration

The regulator and UNDP [named priorities in exploratory discussions — national identity integration with SIM verification, responsible artificial intelligence, stronger data protection and secondary-school digital skills drawing on the universal service fund](#). No memorandum, funding figure or timetable is stated.

Standards

On 3 August the copyright society's blank media levy distribution was reported to rest on records submitted by licensed disc-burning centres rather than on digital consumption, with a proposal to key distribution to digital consumption voted down at an annual general meeting.

Finance

New investments

The governance and service delivery project [closed on 30 June, its grant mechanism continuing under a successor](#). No closing disbursement figure or results statement is held.

ICT Infrastructure

Connectivity

The communications regulator found both mobile operators in breach of the tariff-notice requirement on 17 July 2026, for failing to publish approved tariff changes in at least two daily newspapers seven days before they took effect. Both agreed to credit customers who bought affected products between 26 June and 2 July with bundles equal to the price difference, and to submit evidence of compliance by 31 July ([regulator order](#)). The approved price increase itself stands.

The ICT minister told Parliament on 17 July that additional mobile operator licences are under consideration, and on 24 July that the President had authorised the ministry to identify an investor able to roll out a network without delay; no bid timetable, licence terms or spectrum allocation was stated. The minister also told the House that spectrum licence fees had been reduced by 50%, against the 20% the regulator announced in June 2025 ([parliamentary account](#)).

The gap the licensing round is meant to close acquired figures in August. An industry association report published ahead of its Malawi summit on 20 August [puts fourth-generation coverage at 87% of the population against mobile-internet penetration of 12.5%, with mobile-money adoption described as near universal, and scores Malawi 36 of 100 on its digital nations and society index and 55 of 100 on policy and regulation](#). These are the association's own index and figures; the base still holds no official national subscriber and coverage series.

Data Storage

On 3 July the e-government department agreed integration of immigration e-services onto the national exchange platform ([e-government department](#)).

The revenue authority's own resilience improved on donor money. Its [World Bank-funded secondary data centre and uninterruptible power supply upgrades](#) are reported as improving service continuity, cutting queues and improving customs-duty accuracy at border posts and the international airport, under a six-year, US\$150m regional trade and connectivity project running to 2027. The specific financing commitment date is not stated in the record held, and no capacity, location or availability figure is given for the facility.

Energy

The minister cited an 8% rise in electricity tariffs and a roughly 144% rise in fuel prices in the operators' cost case ([parliamentary account](#)).

DPI

Data Exchange

On 5 August the revenue authority signed an arrangement with its South African counterpart for real-time customs data exchange, with no go-live date and no published purpose-limitation, retention or reciprocity terms ([signing account](#)).

Two days later the South African side notified the update from its end, [publishing the arrangement for automatic exchange of customs information together with a draft rule amendment](#). The rule is still in draft and the go-live date is still unstated.

Digital Identity and CRVS

The registration bureau reported on 13 July 2026 that more than 13.5 million people hold a national digital identity, with over 150,000 enrolled between April and June, 53% of them women ([registration bureau](#)). On 6 July it named the forthcoming mobile credential and set its launch for September 2026 ([registration bureau](#)). On 5 August a separate blockchain-enabled wallet built by the United Nations Development Programme was stated to be in pilot ahead of nationwide rollout; neither announcement names the other.

Using the system got more expensive. The bureau [raised fees for national identity card replacement, electronic know-your-customer verification, civil registration and marriage services](#) under the National Registration (Amendment) Regulations 2026, gazetted on 31 July. The individual fee levels and their previous values are not carried in the record held, so the size of the increase is not established — but the charge for electronic know-your-customer verification is a charge on third parties for using the identity system, levied in the same month the bureau reported approaching universal coverage.

Digital Payments and Fintech

On 25 July the central bank's expected banknote replacement cost for 2026 was reported at MWK 69.8bn against MWK 50.6bn in 2025, with an economists' association president naming government levies on digital money transfers as a reason cash use persists.

Two things moved in the regional rails above it. The regional clearing house [published the scheme rulebook for instant low-cost cross-border retail payments, with a gender audit and strategy to 2030 drawn from research along the corridor with Zambia](#), which gives the platform operational and governance rules it did not have. Separately a commercial bank and an international card scheme [opened online acceptance of that scheme's cards to participating merchants in nine African markets including Malawi on 19 August](#), settling in local currency, US dollars or both; the merchant count is given for the nine markets together and not for Malawi.

Registries

About 8,000 landlords were registered for rental income tax.

Sectoral management information systems

The Electronic Invoicing System reached 8,552 registered taxpayers by 20 July.

Other GovTech and e-Gov

Passport printing resumed at Mangochi, stated in Parliament on 20 July, where a member said applicants who filed nine months to a year earlier were being overtaken by same-day issuances. The homeland security minister accepted in principle a sequence number assigned at application.

A second paper process is being scoped out of existence. The partnership commission and the e-government department are specifying a web-based auctions platform carrying electronic bid submission, automated ranking, bidder anonymity and digital publication of results, with requirements gathered at Blantyre under a World Bank-funded project. No cost, go-live date or auction volume is stated.

Digitalisation

Digitalisation of sub-national government

Parliament ratified an SDR 58.2m grant for the successor local-government service delivery project on 29 July 2026, covering 32 councils with four entering for the first time, of which US\$12.8m funds business-process re-engineering, system assessments and a performance dashboard ([parliamentary approval](#)). The predecessor closed on 30 June.

The results announced on 31 July give the counterpoint. Councils receiving clean audit opinions fell to 18 in 2024/25 from 22 the year before, with one district council receiving an adverse opinion — disclosed at the same event that launched a public real-time dashboard for tracking constituency development spending ([launch account](#)). No address for that dashboard is established in anything the wiki holds, so it cannot be inspected.

Rural digital data capture

Applied deployments in the month were single facilities rather than national systems: a university commissioned an artificial-intelligence fertigation system at its Thyolo campus on 17 July, automating irrigation and fertiliser application from real-time crop data, with no cost or funding source stated.

Technology

AI

A UNESCO artificial intelligence readiness assessment was validated in Lilongwe on 22 July 2026, run by the education ministry rather than by the ICT ministry that owns the draft national strategy. It reported gaps in policy, infrastructure, institutional capacity and education readiness, and put 27.7% of the population online with household computer ownership at 4.2% ([validation account](#)).

On 24 July the Defence Minister stated that the Malawi Defence Force intends to adopt artificial intelligence in military operations and to learn it from the Chinese army, within a relationship he described as extending past exchanges into specialised training, equipment supply and institutional development. No Malawian doctrine, oversight body, budget line or civilian-control provision for military artificial intelligence is on file, and the draft national strategy as reported does not cover it.

Capacity

Training and skills

An operator's school programme reports 36 schools connected with a further nine scheduled in 2026, laboratories equipped with smart televisions and tablets, 12 local e-learning sites zero-rated, and more than 32,000 learners and over 900 teachers benefiting directly. All the figures are the company's own; the continental partnership behind it is worth US\$57m and targets 5,000 schools across 13 countries by 2027. The same foundation's scholarship arm named its first 25 beneficiaries on 18 August, drawn from 17 districts and taking eight programmes at the science and technology university, computer systems and cyber security among them — the places announced at the January launch, filled seven months later. No continuation beyond the one cohort is stated.

Inclusion

Access to services

The first usable figure for how many Malawians are online came from the operators' own trade association rather than from the state. Its report puts 80% of the population offline despite 87% 4G population coverage, and estimates MWK 1.1 trillion of economic value and 490,000 jobs by 2030 from closing the usage gap, setting out six policy priorities for the government and the regulator. The gap it identifies is usage and not coverage, which is a finding the base had no measurement for; the value estimate is modelled by an interested party, and among the six asks is cutting the mobile-service taxes its members pay. Against it stands a presidential target of 80% internet usage by 2026 that has never had a published baseline.

Digital divides

The universal service fund is in operation and funded from the regulator's annual budget allocation, and its director general stated existing funding levels remain insufficient to meet the country's connectivity needs. A school connectivity project runs under it and the secondary-school skills work above is stated to draw on it. No income, balance or disbursement figure is held for any year, and the base holds no regulator annual report or fund account at all.

Data

National statistics

The statistical office and the communications regulator put a Fourth National ICT Survey into the field from August to October across all districts, including the refugee camp at Dzaleka, covering mobile and computer ownership, internet access, digital financial services, e-commerce and cybersecurity awareness. No publication date for the results is stated, which is the part that decides whether it informs anything.

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